

The Noble Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion — A Concise Summary of the Benefits of the Dhāraṇī

Mahākaruṇikā nāma ārya Avalokiteśvara dhāraṇī anuśaṃsa sahita sūtrāt saṃgrahīha · Toh 723 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 723 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Mahākaruṇikā nāma ārya Avalokiteśvara dhāraṇī anuśaṃsa sahita sūtrāt saṃgrahīha, and in Tibetan as the Noble Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion — A Concise Summary of the Benefits of the Dhāraṇī. The text belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and presents itself as a discourse delivered in the presence of the Buddha at Mount Potala, the sacred abode of Avalokiteśvara. In it, the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara himself rises to speak, describing a dhāraṇī of Great Compassion and expounding its spiritual benefits. The work thus combines the sūtra genre with dhāraṇī literature, centering on the compassionate activity of Avalokiteśvara and the power of his quintessential mantra to bring about protection and liberation for beings.

This completes the heart of the purification teaching, together with the four mantra-hearts, the aspiration prayers, the verses, and the mantras.

In Sanskrit: Mahākaruṇikā nāma ārya Avalokiteśvara dhāraṇī anuśaṃsa sahita sūtrāt saṃgrahīha.

In Tibetan: The Noble Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion — A Concise Summary of the Benefits of the Dhāraṇī.

I bow to the noble Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling at Mount Potala, the abode of Avalokiteśvara, surrounded by an immeasurable and incalculable assembly of bodhisattvas. At that moment, the noble Avalokiteśvara rose from his seat, joined his palms together, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"I possess a dhāraṇī called Great Compassion. In order to pacify the heavy obscurations of non-virtue and evil of all sentient beings, to dispel every fear and māra, and to completely satisfy every wish, I shall now teach it."

Having requested permission from the Blessed One to teach it, the Blessed One then said: "Son of good family, the time has come for you to teach this dhāraṇī through the gateway of great compassion. Please teach it swiftly. I and all the buddhas rejoice and give our approval."

Then the bodhisattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Whether a monk or a nun, a male or female lay practitioner, a boy or a girl wishes to recite and uphold this teaching, for the sake of all sentient beings they should first arouse a mind such as this, through the gateway of great compassion:

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly realize all phenomena.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly attain the eye of primordial wisdom.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly liberate all sentient beings.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly obtain skillful means.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly cross over on the vessel of wisdom.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly pass beyond the ocean of suffering.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly attain the path trodden by the feet of moral discipline.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly climb the mountain of nirvāṇa.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly arrive at the house of the unconditioned.

I bow to Avalokiteśvara, Lord of Great Compassion.

May I swiftly come to be equal to the body of dharmatā.

If I must climb a mountain of swords,

may the mountain of swords collapse of itself.

If I must pass through a burning sea of hot water,

may the burning sea cool and become still of itself.

If I go to the hell of sentient beings,

may that hell dry up of itself.

If I go to the realm of hungry ghosts,
may their hunger and thirst be satisfied.
If I go to the realm of asuras,
may their malicious minds be tamed of themselves.
If I go to the realm of animals,
may I myself obtain great wisdom.

Having made these aspiration prayers in such words, with one-pointed mind one should recite and call to mind my name. Furthermore, one should recite the name of my teacher, the Tathāgata Amitābha. Then, if one recites this dhāraṇī once or up to seven times —"

— all the heavy offenses that would cause one to roam in cyclic existence for however many hundreds of thousands of millions of eons will be cleared away and purified. If one recites and holds this great compassion dhāraṇī, then at the time of death the Tathāgatas of the ten directions will come to that place and extend their hands, and one will be born in whichever buddha-field one wishes to be born in, just as one has aspired.

The following words were also addressed to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if any sentient being who recites and fully holds this awareness-mantra of great compassion were to fall into the three lower destinies, I vow that I shall never attain perfect, complete awakening. If those who recite and fully hold this awareness-mantra of great compassion were not to attain immeasurable meditative absorption and boundless confidence, I vow that I shall never attain perfect, complete awakening. If all the aspirations made in this very life by those who recite and fully hold this awareness-mantra of great compassion were not to be fulfilled just as they have aspired, then I would not call it the dhāraṇī of the mind of great compassion — with the sole exception of those who have acted with non-virtue and with undivided mind. As for any woman who, utterly weary of a woman's body, wishes to obtain a man's body: if she recites and fully holds the words of this dhāraṇī of the mind of great compassion and yet does not, upon passing from a woman's body, attain a man's body, I vow that I shall never attain perfect, complete awakening. Yet if even a trace of doubt arises in the mind, the desired result will certainly not be accomplished."

Having spoken thus, he joined his palms before the assembled retinue, sat upright, and, generating the mind of great compassion toward all sentient

beings, with a smiling countenance recited these excellent words of the dhāraṇī called "The Mind of Great Compassion, Vast and Perfect, Unobstructed" —

The heart-essence is: Om maṇi padme hūṃ.

The dhāraṇī is: Namo ratnatrayāya. Nama āryāvalokiteśvarāya bodhisattvāya mahāsattvāya mahākāruṇikāya. Tadyathā: oṃ sarva-bandhana-cchedana-karāya sarva-pāpa-samudra-uccoṣaṇa-karāya sarva-vyādhi-praśamana-karāya sarva-ityupadrava-vināśana-karāya sarva-bhayeṣu trāṇāya. Tasya namaskṛtvā idaṃ āryāvalokiteśvara-tava-nīlakaṇṭha-nāma-hṛdayam āvartayiṣyāmi sarva-artha-sādhana śubha-cetana sarva-sattvānāṃ pāpa-mārga-viśodhaka. Tadyathā: avaloki loka-mati loka-gati. Ehy ehi mahābodhisattva. He bodhisattva, he mahābodhisattva, he priya-bodhisattva. He kāruṇika smara hṛdayam. Ehy ehi āryāvalokiteśvara parama-maitrī-citta-kāruṇika. Kuru kuru karma, sādahaya sādahaya. Vidyāṃ dehi dehi me. Araṃ gamam gama. Vihaṃgama mahāsiddha-yogeśvara. Duhu duhu. Vīryante mahāvīryante. Dhara dhara dhāraṇīśvara. Jvala jvala vimala amala. Mārti āryāvalokiteśvara kṛṣṇa ajina jaṭā-makuṭa alaṃkṛta-śarīra. Alaṃba pralaṃba vilamba. Mahāsiddha śuddha-dhara. Bala bala mahābala. Mahāmala mahāmala. Jvala jvala mahājvala. Kṛṣṇa-pakṣa kṛṣṇa-varṇa kṛṣṇa-pāśa nirghātana. He padma-hasta jaya-kara niśācareśvara. Kṛṣṇa sarva-kṛta-yajñopavīta. Ehy ehi vārāha-mukha tri-pura-dhaṇīśvara nārāyaṇa-pāla-rūpa-peṣa-dhari. He nīlakaṇṭha, he mahā-hālāhara viṣa-nirjita-lokasya. Rāga-viṣa-nāśana dveṣa-viṣa-nāśana moha-viṣa-nāśana nirmokṣaṇa. Hulu hulu, muñca muñca, muhulu muhulu, hāla hāla. Mahāpadma-nābhi. Sara sara siri siri.

Suru suru. Buddhya buddhya. Bodhaya bodhaya. Bodhayāmi. Tava nīlakaṇṭha. Ehy ehi nīlakaṇṭha. Ehy ehi vāmasthita. Siddhamukha. Hasa hasa. Muñca muñca. Mahāaṭṭāṭṭahāsa-nirnadini. Ehy ehi. Bho bho mahāsiddha-yogīśvara. Bandha bandha, vacaṃ sādahaya sādahaya. Vidyāṃ smara smara tvām. He bhagavan. Loka-vilokastvaṃ. Tathāgatādāhi me darśanaṃ. Prasādhayāmi svāhā. Siddhāya svāhā. Mahāsiddhāya svāhā. Siddha-yogīśvarāya svāhā. Nīlakaṇṭhāya svāhā. Vārāha-mukhāya svāhā. Siddha-mukhāya svāhā. Mahā-nara-siddha-mukhāya svāhā. Siddha-vidyādhārāya svāhā. Padma-hastāya svāhā. Mahāpadma-hastāya svāhā. Vajra-hastāya svāhā. Mahāvajra-hastāya svāhā. Kṛṣṇa-sarpa-kṛta-yajñopavītāya svāhā. Mahākāla-mukuṭa-dhārāya svāhā. Cakrāyudha-dhārāya svāhā. Śaṅkhe-śabda-nirnadana-karāya svāhā. Bodhana-karāya svāhā.

Vāma-skandha-deśasthita-kṛṣṇa-ajināya svāhā.
Vāma-haste-vyāghra-carma-nivāsanāya svāhā. Lokeśvarāya svāhā.
Mahālokeśvarāya svāhā. Sarva-siddheśvara svāhā. Rakṣa rakṣa māṃ svāhā.
Kuru rakṣa mūrtināṃ svāhā. Namō bhagavate ārya-Avalokiteśvarāya,
bodhisattvāya, mahāsattvāya, mahākāruṇikāya. Siddhyantu me
mantra-padāni svāhā.

Then, after the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara had finished teaching this dhāraṇī,
for the benefit of those who recite and perfectly uphold it, and in order to
dispel all harm and obstacles, he spoke these supremely joyous verses:

One who has gone to the mountains, the wilds, or a remote desert place,
and there encounters fierce tigers, wolves, and predatory animals,
or scorpions, snakes, and malevolent spirits and demons —
upon hearing this dhāraṇī recited, they cannot cause harm.

One who has entered a river or the great ocean
and there faces venomous nāgas, unruly sea monsters,
yakṣas, rākṣasas, fish, and tortoises —
upon hearing this dhāraṇī, each and every one will scatter.

One who is engaged in battle, surrounded by enemies,
or when vicious robbers come to seize one's wealth —
if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
those enemies will give rise to loving hearts and turn back.

One who is caught in a royal legal case,
or when fettered in iron chains and cast into prison —
if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
the king, moved by loving kindness, will set one free.

One who has entered a house bewitched by sorcery and poison,
and is being killed by poisoned food or drink —
if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
the poison will be neutralized and the food and drink themselves become pure.

When a pregnant woman is giving birth to a child,
and obstructed by māra she suffers unbearable pain —
if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
the possessing spirits will be expelled and she will give birth with ease.

When a fierce nāga possession breathes its toxic breath upon one,
and burning fever threatens one's life with imminent death —

if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
the epidemic disease will be dispelled and one's life will be prolonged.

When afflicted by a roaming nāga possession causing swelling,
and painful tumors that weep with unbearable discharge of pus and blood —
if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
applying saliva three times will bring the swelling to rest.

When sentient beings, their minds turbid and acting non-virtuously,
are tormented by sorcery, cursing mantras, and enemies —
if one recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion with single-pointed mind,
the one who sent the sorcery and possession will bow down.

In a degenerate age when negativity proliferates and the sacred Dharma
declines,

when the fire of desire blazes and minds are confused and perverted,
when spouses turn apart from each other, each lusting after someone else,
and day and night wrong thoughts flow on without ceasing —
whoever recites this dhāraṇī of great compassion —

the fire of desire will be quenched and perverted minds will be cleared away.

If I were to proclaim the full power and might of this dhāraṇī,
even speaking for an entire eon I could not reach its end —
the mind would tire before the telling was done.

If those who recite and hold this dhāraṇī of great compassion should enter a
river or the ocean and bathe there, then the water that has washed their
bodies — should it touch the bodies of whatever sentient beings dwell in those
waters — will purify and completely cleanse away all their negative karma and
the heavy weight of every blameworthy transgression. Those beings will then
take birth by miraculous arising on a lotus in another pure realm, and will
never again take up a body born from a womb, from warmth and moisture, or
from an egg. How much more, then, need be said of those who actually recite
this dhāraṇī and hold it themselves.

When those who recite and hold this dhāraṇī are traveling along a road and a
great wind arises — whatever wind brushes against that person's body, hair,
and clothing — should it then touch the bodies of other sentient beings in the
direction it carries, all their obscurations and the heavy weight of their
negative karma, without exception, will be completely purified. They will never

experience the karmic ripening of any of the three lower destinies, and will be reborn always in the presence of a buddha. Therefore, know that the benefits of hearing this dhāraṇī for those who recite and hold it are inconceivable.

This concludes the sūtra excerpt entitled "The Dhāraṇī of Great Compassion of the Noble Avalokiteśvara, Together with Its Benefits."

Translated by the monk Śākya Yeshe.

Translator's Notes

- The opening Sanskrit title and its Tibetan translation together form the full title of the text: a sūtra compiling the benefits of Avalokiteśvara's Great Compassion dhāraṇī. The Sanskrit as it appears in the Tibetan is phonetically rendered and has been reproduced here in normalized Sanskrit spelling following the Tibetan transliteration.

The phrase rendered "the body of dharmatā" translates chos nyid kyi sku, meaning a body or state co-extensive with the nature of reality itself, a relatively unusual expression that may indicate ultimate buddhahood understood through the Madhyamaka lens of dharmatā.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as it does in the source, with the conditional clause about reciting the dhāraṇī once or up to seven times left open, indicating the text continues beyond this excerpt.

- The dhāraṇī passage is rendered in reconstructed Sanskrit transcription from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of the Sanskrit. The Tibetan here preserves a well-known version of the Nīlakaṇṭha dhāraṇī associated with Avalokiteśvara. Several syllables in the Tibetan phonetic spelling admit minor variant readings; the reconstruction follows the most standard attested Sanskrit form of this dhāraṇī as found in parallel versions of the text. The phrase "tava-nīlakaṇṭha-nāma-hṛdayam" in the dhāraṇī refers to Avalokiteśvara's epithet Nīlakaṇṭha, "Blue-throated," borrowed from Śiva but here applied to the bodhisattva. The vow structure in this passage follows the classical format of bodhisattva pranidhāna-vows, each concluding with the pledge not to attain full buddhahood should the stated benefit fail to occur — the sole explicit exception being non-virtue combined with one-pointed non-virtuous intention, which is a standard caveat in such formulas.

- The passage is the concluding section of the dhāraṇī of Avalokiteśvara, followed by benedictory verses enumerating protective powers. The final verse is incomplete as given in the source text, ending mid-stanza; the translation preserves the break exactly as it appears. The term rendered "scorpions" for skorpiṇi is somewhat uncertain — it can denote scorpions or certain insects — but scorpion is the standard interpretation in this liturgical context. "Saliva applied three times" in the swelling verse refers to a classical Indic healing practice associated with dhāraṇī recitation.

- The closing colophon names the translator as the monk Śākya Yeshe, a well-known early Tibetan translator active during the imperial period. The phrase rendered "warmth and moisture" refers to the traditional category of beings born from moisture and heat combined, one of the four modes of birth in Buddhist cosmology. The three lower destinies are the hells, the realm of hungry ghosts, and the animal realm.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.